# How I design learning

A six-step process for training that people remember and use. Version 1, 2026.

Sector: Method, all sectors

Status: concept study, written and designed by Karthik Bindumon, 2026. Numbers are targets or modelled assumptions and are labelled as such.

Method: The Realisation Loop, v1 (see 00-realisation-loop.pdf).

A working model for learning that arrives as a discovery rather than an instruction. It comes out of five years producing games and the observation that players remember what they worked out and forget what a tutorial told them. Every case in the portfolio runs on it. It is a version 1: use it, break it, tell me where it fails.

## The claim

> **A fact you were told competes with a thousand others. A fact you were caught by, mid-play, has already been used once. That is the difference between memory and retention.**

## The six stages

| Stage | Design question | Grounding |
|---|---|---|
| 1 Encounter | What does the learner meet first, before any words? | Bateson (play frame), Winnicott (potential space) |
| 2 Friction | What small, safe failure do they hit in the first minute? | Bjork (desirable difficulties), Vygotsky (ZPD) |
| 3 Guess | What will they try, and does the system let them try it? | Papert (constructionism), Bruner (enactive stage), Gee (games as hypothesis engines) |
| 4 Play | How many cheap loops before the pattern shows? | Csikszentmihalyi (flow), Schultz (reward prediction error) |
| 5 Realise | What is the single sentence they say to themselves? | Gestalt insight (Kohler, Duncker), generation effect (Slamecka and Graf) |
| 6 Carry | What cue in their real day brings it back? | Gollwitzer (implementation intentions), Ebbinghaus (spacing), Perkins and Salomon (transfer) |

## How to use it in a design review

Walk the six questions in order and write one sentence for each. A blank at stage 5 means the design has no realisation and will not be remembered; go back to stage 2 and make the friction sharper. A blank at stage 6 means it will be remembered and never used; add a real-world cue before you add any content.

The loop is neutral about medium. Threshold runs it on a floor tile, Kata on a warehouse shelf, Roti on paper and scissors, Rep on a loop of beads, Salary Day on a phone. If a medium cannot carry stage

3 (the learner actually trying something), choose another medium.

## Where it fails

Compliance content with legal wording that must be recited exactly. Any audience that cannot afford a safe failure (some clinical and safety contexts; here stage 2 has to move into a simulator). Very short interventions under two minutes where there is no room for a loop. In those cases I use spaced retrieval without the play frame, and say so.

## Ethics line

The loop uses behavioural science the learner can see. The realisation belongs to them and they can name it. Anything designed to work on a person without their knowledge is out of scope for this model and for my practice.